

****Closing Social Media to Younger Users. A Girl Who Stabs Another Cannot Become a Spectacle****

It is undeniably late, but it is better to take social media away from young people today than to have to do it tomorrow in emergency conditions in the face of the next tragedy that ends worse than the one we are discussing.

****Intervention by Guido Scorza, Member of the Guarantor for the Protection of Personal Data****
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If two girls aged 14 and 15 arrange to meet, in broad daylight, in the middle of a street to challenge each other in an improvised asphalt ring, and if one of them, in the second round, is handed a knife by a third peer and stabs the challenger, sending her to the hospital in critical condition, the blame does not lie with social media or, at least, it does not lie with social media more than it does with a media system that, long before social media, has promoted violence, proposed negative role models, and downplayed the incivility of people as a phenomenon inherent to society.

But if around the two girls engaged in a duel with weapons a circle of adolescent spectators forms, who instead of inviting them to stop and trying to separate them brandish smartphones and, pushing through the heads of those in a better position, engage in Oscar-worthy filming, sometimes venturing into commentary worthy of the big screen, and if even before the stabbed girl arrives in the ambulance and it is known whether she is alive or dead, the videos in question end up on social media in search of likes, social media cannot be absolved, even though they are certainly not the only ones responsible.

If those social media had not existed, if those kids, unable to understand the dynamics of how they work, the media firepower, and the traps of the invitation to share what should not even be recorded, had been blocked on the login page of wonderful tools not designed and not intended to become the natural living space of hundreds of millions of children and adolescents, if those videos filmed by their smartphones had been condemned to remain prisoners, perhaps someone would have allowed humanity to prevail over the macabre and uncivilized frenzy of capturing everything to be the first to shout in the social universe that they took part in that wild ritual, and someone might have managed to prevent a schoolmate, a fourteen-year-old girl, from ending up in the hospital stabbed by another fifteen-year-old girl.

But social media exists, and due to a huge cultural misunderstanding, we continue to believe that while it is too dangerous to let a child ride a scooter or a car, it is absolutely normal for them to use it, regardless of their age. This is not the case, and not because social media represents a digital hell, are dangerous in themselves, or carry some sort of disvalue, but simply because, despite their apparent simplicity and ease of use with which they have won over adults and children, they are extraordinarily complex services designed and intended with one real goal: to capture the time and attention of as many people as possible for the declared purpose of collecting personal data from which to extract invaluable information for global markets, not just advertising.

Consequently, the algorithms and interfaces that represent their soul and body inevitably create dependency, play on our weaknesses to enchant us, literally make us prisoners, invite us to share more and more, and daily present us with fragments of real joys and sorrows of billions of people as if they were irresistible entertainment content. It is our lives that are staged on social media, and their algorithms turn even a drama of incivility and inhumanity, such as that of a girl stabbing another almost to death, into a spectacle, rewarding those who publish the gruesome images and the wild screams with the ephemeral currency of popularity, simultaneously inviting billions of users to view them.

Then, for goodness' sake, when the line is crossed and there is a risk that certain content could damage the reputation of the commercial companies that control them or, in any case, expose their stock value to excessive risk, they intervene to block its circulation. But, generally, by that point, it is too late. The message has passed, the idea that everything can be shared with all of humanity has passed, and all that remains is to wait for a new real-life episode to transform into a spectacle, completely eroding the boundary between sometimes dramatic and painful reality and cinematic fiction.

We must close social media to younger users; we must stop considering it a neo-Luddite idea just because we have realized late the necessity of doing so when we had already learned to consider it normal to hold our children's hands and, indeed, to consider social media their digital babysitter. It is undeniably late, but it is better to do it today than to have to do it tomorrow in emergency conditions in the face of the next tragedy that ends worse than the one we are discussing.